troops had returned home—and, apart from being staunchly anti-Chinese, the Tibetans were of the opinion that the crest of the mountains was where their jurisdiction ended.

Maxwell, however, has a different version of the significance of the border markers and where the border should be, 'The Chinese…put up border markers in 1910, and the Tibetans maintained that the boundary lay there and not some twenty miles upstream where the McMahon Line put it'.[26] It is unclear on what Maxwell based his assertion of some kind of consensus between the Tibetans and the Chinese on the border issue. It is highly unlikely, and, in any case, those markers stood there for just over two years.

The Chinese invasion of Tibet in 1950 dramatically altered the geopolitics of the entire region. Tibet, which until then had had closer ties to India than China, was no longer a de facto independent country. One of the few in the Indian government who understood the profound significance of this change was the home minister, Vallabhbhai Patel, who, only a month before his death in December 1950, wrote to Nehru,

> We have to consider what the new situation now faces us as a result of the disappearance of Tibet, as we know it, and the expansion of China up to our gates. Throughout history, we have seldom been worried about our north-east frontier. The Himalayas has been regarded as an impenetrable barrier against threats from the north. We had a friendly Tibet which gave us no trouble. The Chinese were divided. They had their domestic problems and never bothered us about our frontiers.[27]

But the idealist Nehru, who failed to understand the mindset of Beijing's new communist rulers, continued to believe in friendship with China. India and China, in his view, were both countries which had risen from repression and should work together with all the newly liberated countries in Asia and Africa. And, in the 1950s, relations between India and China seemed to blossom under the Hindi slogan *Hindi Chini Bhai Bhai* or 'Indians and Chinese are brothers'.

India officially recognized Chinese sovereignty over Tibet for the first time through the 1954 Agreement between the Republic of India and the People's Republic of China on Trade and Intercourse between India and the Tibet Region of China'.[28] But India had, in effect, recognized Tibet as part of China in September 1952, when it formally agreed with the Chinese authorities, rather than with the Tibetans, to change the status of its mission